

Culture

Culture is how people actually behave when no one's watching. It's not mission statements or values posters — it's what happens in practice.

Psychological Safety

Psychological safety means people feel safe to:

- Ask “dumb” questions
- Admit they don't know something
- Disagree with the senior person in the room
- Point out problems without fear of punishment
- Take risks and sometimes fail

Without psychological safety, people hide problems until they're too big to hide. They don't ask for help when they're stuck. They don't raise concerns about bad decisions.

This isn't about being nice. It's about getting accurate information so you can make good decisions.

Trust

Trust has two components:

- **Competence trust** — I believe you can do your job well
- **Character trust** — I believe you have good intentions

Trust is built through:

- **Reliability** — Doing what you say you'll do
- **Vulnerability** — Admitting mistakes and limitations
- **Consistency** — Behaving predictably over time

Trust is slow to build and fast to destroy. One betrayal can undo months of good behavior.

Continuous Improvement

Healthy teams constantly ask: “How can we do better?”

Retrospectives are a common practice:

1. What went well?
2. What didn't go well?
3. What will we change?

The key word is *change*. A retrospective that generates insights but no action is theater.

Cargo Cult Retrospectives

Watch for retrospectives that:

- Generate the same complaints every time with no action
- Avoid the real issues because they're uncomfortable
- Become blame sessions instead of improvement discussions
- Are skipped when the team is “too busy”

If your retros aren't leading to change, they're not working. Either fix them or stop pretending.

Ownership and Autonomy

The Agile principles say: “Build projects around motivated individuals. Give them the environment and support they need, and trust them to get the job done.”

This means:

- Teams decide *how* to do the work, not just *what* to do

- People closest to the problem make decisions about it
- Micromanagement signals lack of trust and kills motivation

Autonomy requires competence. You earn trust by demonstrating good judgment.

Learning from Failure

Failure is inevitable. The question is whether you learn from it.

Blameless postmortems focus on:

- What happened? (Timeline of events)
- Why did it happen? (Root causes, not surface symptoms)
- How do we prevent it? (Systemic changes)

The goal is never “who do we punish?” That just teaches people to hide failures.

Culture is Set by Leadership

Culture flows from the top. If leaders:

- Blame people for failures → People hide problems
- Reward heroics → People create crises to look heroic
- Say quality matters but ship garbage → People learn words don't matter
- Admit their own mistakes → Others feel safe to do the same

Watch what gets rewarded and punished. That's the real culture, regardless of what's written on the wall.